Bengal Native Infantry.[20] Within five years, over 500 Indian merchants referred to as the Chulias arrived in Singapore, followed by Indian convicts, after a detention facility was set up. The first mosques and temples were also established in the 1820s.

Singapore was a part of the British-ruled Straits Settlements from 1826 to 1942. For the first four decades, it was governed as an extension of British India. During this period, it developed as a port and site for plantations producing spices, sugar and eventually rubber. As in Malaya, Tamil indentured labour was brought to work on the plantations, Punjabi Sikhs were brought in to staff the police, and mercantile castes from different parts of India came in as traders. One such trader, of spices and cotton, became an extremely famous personality in Singapore's history. Rajabali Jumabhoy (1898–2001) was one among the few individuals who lived through all the years of the 20th century.[21] Born into a Kachchhi Khoja Muslim family, he moved from Kachchh to Singapore in 1916. Within a few decades of trade and real estate investment, his firm rose to become one of the wealthiest business houses of Singapore. He also helped establish the Singapore Indian Association in 1923, Singapore Indian Chamber of Commerce in 1935 and Singapore Indian Congress in 1945. He arranged for the evacuation of Indians during the Japanese occupation in World War II, at a time when the island attracted followers of the Indian National Army (INA) to mobilize violently against the British forces. But as with many family businesses in India, his business dynasty disintegrated in the 1990s.

In the 1950s, some 40,000 Indians in Malaya migrated to Singapore to escape Emergency rule, but restrictive immigration laws soon constrained further Indian migration to the city. After independence in 1965, Singapore witnessed astonishing economic growth amidst sustained efforts to preserve its multi-ethnic demographic composition. As a result, Indians became Indian-Singaporean and shared the benefits of economic growth, supplemented by the migration of highly skilled professionals since the 1990s. The emphasis on English in the Indian community also paid rich dividends. Serangoon Road, the historic hub of Indian activities, is today